

Chapter 99-5

Xu Qingzhu didn't know if she could still ask her follow-up questions. After hesitating, she chose not to ask, but instead said softly, "I'm not speaking on Dr. Zhao's behalf. It's just that you surely have your reasons for breaking up, and you have your reasons for not forgiving her."

Xu Qingzhu said, "Liang Shi and I shouldn't have interfered with the relationship between you two, but Liang Shi went to your apartment before."

Shen Hui paused. "Which one?"

"The one in Chenjiang Community." Xu Qingzhu said. "We're living on the 10th floor now, because Dr. Zhao said your birthday is in October."

Shen Hui lowered her eyes, her tone softening with a hint of tenderness. "So you're living there now."

"What about the top floor?" Shen Hui asked.

Xu Qingzhu said, "It's still empty. Liang Shi said there are too many memories of you two there—precious and beautiful—so she kept it for Dr. Zhao."

Shen Hui suddenly chuckled softly. "But no matter how precious and beautiful memories are, they can only ever be memories."

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment. "Although I don't know what happened between you two, Dr. Zhao really loves you. You should understand her better than we do, right? She's not great with words, and she's quite tsundere.¹ When I first met her, I thought there was no way I could ever become friends with her, but later... I felt like she's really a person of integrity."

The word Liang Shi had once used to describe Zhao Xuning really couldn't be more fitting.

"Being the kind of friend who doesn't need to be too close to her is very comfortable." Xu Qingzhu said. "She's helped us a lot. I have no way to repay her, so I can only come bother you with a few words."

Shen Hui chuckled softly. "A person of integrity?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Her reason for not dating is because she can't forget her ex-girlfriend."

"However..." Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly. "If she did something unforgivable to you, then just move forward. No matter how much she loves you, that's her business. You don't need to be morally blackmailed."

Shen Hui rested her chin on her hand, her eyes half-closed. The atmosphere suddenly fell silent.

After a long while, Shen Hui said slowly, "Back then, what she lost wasn't just me, but also our child."

Shen Hui's eyes reddened. "She didn't do anything wrong, and I didn't do anything wrong either. But we lost our child. So that means she was wrong, and I was wrong too."

Xu Qingzhu hurriedly handed her tissues. Shen Hui's tears fell, glistening teardrops hanging on her long eyelashes.

Shen Hui wiped them away, then said to Xu Qingzhu, "You're right. I understand better than anyone what kind of person Zhao Xuning is."

After a long silence, her nose stung with emotion and she turned her face away. "That's exactly why I can't forgive her even more."

Rather than saying she couldn't forgive her, it would be more accurate to say she couldn't forgive herself.

Zhao Xuning had always kept her distance from other women. She was never ambiguous with anyone. In five years of dating, Shen Hui had almost never seen any flirtatious messages on her phone.

Yet on that particular day, she was tricked into going to a birthday party and drank spiked alcohol.

And Shen Hui just happened to see it.

What about her then?

She knew Zhao Xuning wasn't that kind of person, but she still lost control when she saw that scene.

Someone who had never suffered any grievances—how could she have such a strong heart? She was so angry that she went out into the rain and got knocked down by someone.

She had just found out there was a little life in her belly. She had fantasized about it for so long at home, even coming up with more than a dozen names for Zhao Xuning to choose from. But before Zhao Xuning even knew the little life existed, the child was gone.

In less than twelve hours.

Her hopes and expectations were shattered in less than twelve hours.

She couldn't get past it.

She was wrong, and Zhao Xuning was wrong too.

They were both paying for their own mistakes.

Shen Hui rarely talked about this with others. She rarely even mentioned that she once had a child.

But suddenly bringing it up, she found it wasn't that hard to say after all.

Shen Hui looked at Xu Qingzhu. "Little sister, she's a person of integrity, and she still loves me, but there's no going back for us."

Xu Qingzhu met her gaze, then suddenly raised her hand to wipe away her tears.

Her cool fingernips touched the area under Shen Hui's eyes. Xu Qingzhu said gently, "Jiejie, let me treat you to drinks sometime."

Shen Hui raised an eyebrow. The corners of her mouth slowly curved up into a captivating smile. "Oh?"

"To the present." Xu Qingzhu said. "To freedom."

Not a single mention of Zhao Xuning.

Xu Qingzhu said, "If a relationship is a swamp, then we stride forward. Our lives move in many directions, not just straight down."

Shen Hui: "Oh?"

Xu Qingzhu patted her arm. "What I mean is, there are plenty of people in this world who are better than Dr. Zhao."

Shen Hui: "....."

She switched sides just like that?

Shen Hui was amused by her. "Add me on WeChat."

Xu Qingzhu took out her QR code. "When you have a day off, let me know. I'll treat you to drinks."

Shen Hui nodded. "Sure, but you can't bring that person."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Shen Hui said, "Girls' gatherings don't include partners."

"Okay." Xu Qingzhu agreed readily.

Footnotes:

¹ Tsundere (傲娇, àojiāo): A Japanese term that has been adopted into Chinese internet slang. It describes a personality type that is initially cold, aloof, or even hostile on the outside, but gradually shows a warmer, more caring side. The word combines "tsuntsun" (aloof/cold) and "dederere" (lovestruck/affectionate).